

CHAPTER 10

Marriage and Money

It wasn't so long ago that marriage was only about money. Aligning financial interests, consolidating power between two families, rich dowries, and arable land—and not love, romance, and attraction—were the crucial components of a strong union. Our ancestors knew that when you marry, you marry each other's money, debts, and spending and saving habits.

I'm not advocating a return to arranged marriages, but if I have any goal in writing this book, it's to encourage open communication between couples about money, *before* they take the big plunge. Studies and polls consistently reveal that money problems ruin more relationships than infidelity. Yet many of these same polls and studies claim that people have a harder time talking about money problems than sex issues. Imagine if you discovered your partner-to-be had a history of gambling. You'd be right to cancel the wedding. So why would you head down the aisle with someone carrying \$60,000 of credit card debt? Isn't that proof enough that your partner has gambled his or her future away? And if your fiancé(e) is having a torrid affair with money, it can be as insidious and destructive to your future marriage as an illicit affair.

Take the example of a couple I know, Sally and Frederick. Frederick is a hotshot commercial director who earns about \$175,000 a year. As a high school English teacher, Sally earns less, about \$65,000. They love each other very much, but they are about to embark upon the most debt-inducing journey they will ever go on in their lives: marriage.